

Calculate with a clear process

Tactics exploit short-term features of a position. Good calculation tests an idea against resistance.

Spot the clues. Scan for undefended pieces, exposed kings, pieces on the same line, trapped pieces, and defenders with more than one job. A clue suggests where to look; it does not prove a combination.

Choose candidates. Start with checks, captures, and direct threats. Add a quiet move when it creates a threat or fixes a tactical problem. Do not assume every position contains a winning tactic.

Search for the strongest defense. Your opponent may ignore your threat, give check, trade queens, or capture a different piece. Test those possibilities rather than assuming the reply that makes your idea work.

Track the board accurately. After each imagined move, update the moved piece, any captured piece, and the lines that opened. At a branch point, return to the original position before trying another line.

Evaluate the resulting position. Count material only after the immediate sequence settles. Then check king safety, trapped pieces, pawn promotion, and continuing threats. A temporary material gain may disappear.

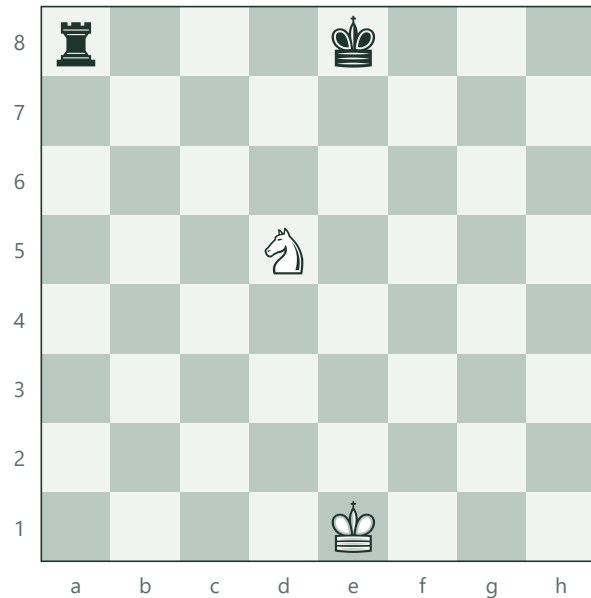
Pattern	What to look for
Fork	One piece attacks two or more targets at once.
Pin / skewer	A valuable target lies behind another piece on a line.
Discovered attack	Moving one piece uncovers an attack by another.
Removal of a defender	A target becomes vulnerable when its guard is captured or driven away.
Zwischenzug	A forcing in-between move is stronger than the expected recapture.

PRACTICE THESE MOTIFS

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Exercise: make two threats at once

Set up the diagram. Before reading the answer, find White's forcing move and calculate a reply.



Targets

Black has a king on e8 and a rook on a8. White's knight starts on d5.

Your task

Which knight move attacks both targets? Why does attacking the king first make the tactic effective?

Before you commit

Check that the knight's destination is legal and that Black cannot capture the knight in response.

White to move. Find a knight fork.

ANSWER

1.Nc7+ forks the king on e8 and the rook on a8. Black must answer the check. For example, 1...Kd7 2.Nxa8 wins the rook. In this diagram, Black has no way to capture the checking knight or interpose against its check.

Why the move works

The two black pieces are within the knight's reach from c7. Because one target is the king, Black cannot simply move the rook away. The force of the check gives White time to take the other target.

What to carry into real games

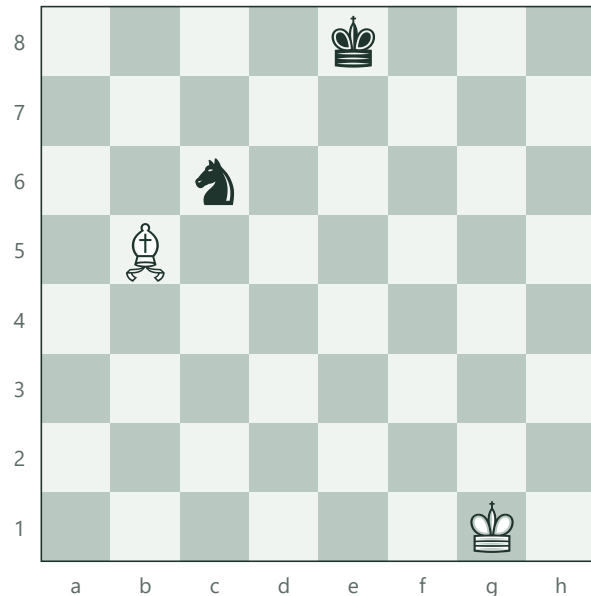
Before placing your king, queen, and rooks, check whether a knight can attack two of them from one square. Defensively, moving one target or controlling the fork square may remove the tactic.

Make the exercise harder

Cover the board and visualize d5-c7-a8. Then rebuild the position from memory. Accurate visualization is useful even when the combination itself is short.

Exercise: a defender that cannot move

A piece can appear available for a job while being constrained by the safety of its king.



Find the line

White's bishop on b5 points through c6 and d7 toward the black king on e8.

Your task

Can Black legally move the knight from c6? Explain what would happen to the king.

Useful distinction

An absolute pin involves the king. A relative pin involves a different valuable piece, such as the queen.

Black to move. Inspect the knight on c6.

ANSWER

No knight move is legal here. Moving the knight would uncover the bishop's attack on the king. Black must choose a legal king move. The diagram illustrates a restriction; it is not a claim that White can force a win.

Use pins without overestimating them

Adding pressure to a pinned piece can win material, but first check whether the opponent can break the pin, move the king, exchange the pinning piece, or create a stronger threat. A relative pin can be broken if the resulting trade is favorable.

Count defenders carefully

Ask whether a defender can legally perform the recapture you expect. However, a pinned piece still attacks squares for king-movement rules: do not move your king onto a square attacked by an enemy piece merely because that piece is pinned.

PRACTICE AND RULE REFERENCE: ARTICLE 3.1.3

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FIDE Laws of Chess - handbook.fide.com/chapter/e012023